

We Tested 11 Automatic Cat Feeders: These Are the Ones That Actually Deliver

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If your cat has ever treated your face like a breakfast buffet at dawn, you know the struggle. Automatic cat feeders promise liberation, but not all are created equal. WIRED put 11 models through their paces, and the results reveal a new generation of smart feeders that go way beyond kibble on a timer.

The standout for dry food is the Petkit YumShare Dual-Hopper 2 (\$170). It features a **dual hopper** for two food types, a crystal-clear 1080p camera with night vision, and crucially AI that analyzes remaining food in the bowl to prevent overfeeding. The app lets you schedule meals, dispense snacks, and even talk to your cat via two-way audio. No subscription is needed for the AI, which can recognize up to 20 individual pets and log their meals.

For wet food, the Petlibro Polar Smart Wet Feeder (\$170) is a game-changer. It's essentially a **thermoelectric** mini-fridge that keeps food at or below 50°F, pausing cooling 30 minutes before mealtime to serve it at the ideal temperature. The three stainless steel bowls are wide and shallow to prevent **whisker fatigue** and **feline acne**. A sensor ensures the lid doesn't close while your cat is eating. Our tester loved it so much they bought a second one.

Budget-conscious buyers aren't left out. The Petlibro Granary Camera Feeder (\$100) offers a reliable app, HD camera, and customizable meal plans. The Petlibro Air Feeder (\$60) is a sleek, no-frills option with a **rechargeable battery** and tiny portion sizes for snack control. Even the Oneisall 2-in-1 Dual Feeder (\$50) gets the job done, though its app can be **buggy**.

Whether you're managing a greedy eater, a picky nibbler, or just want to sleep past sunrise, the right automatic feeder can be a small revolution. Your cat might still rule the house, but at least you'll get to set the breakfast schedule.

Word Treasure

thermoelectric -- A cooling technology that uses electricity to move heat, allowing a device to stay cold without a compressor like a regular fridge.

whisker fatigue -- A condition where a cat's sensitive whiskers become overstimulated from touching the sides of a deep food bowl, causing stress or refusal to eat.

feline acne -- A skin condition in cats where small blackheads or pimples appear on the chin, sometimes caused by bacteria from plastic bowls.

dual hopper -- A feeder with two separate storage containers, allowing an owner to dispense two different types of dry food or mix them in meals.

rechargeable battery -- A power source that can be charged again after use, so the device doesn't need to stay plugged into a wall outlet all the time.

buggy -- Having software errors or glitches that cause an app or device to behave unexpectedly or freeze.

Background you need

Automatic pet feeders have been around for decades, but early models were simple timers that dumped kibble into a bowl at set hours, often jamming or dispensing too much. The rise of smart home tech has turned them into Wi-Fi-connected devices with cameras, apps, and even machine learning.

Petkit and Petlibro are two leading Chinese brands in the smart pet market, competing with Western companies by offering advanced features like app-controlled feeding and pet recognition at lower prices. WIRED is a tech and culture magazine known for its in-depth product reviews.

Veterinarians warn that cats fed only dry food may not get enough moisture, which is why wet food feeders are gaining attention. However, leaving wet food out too long at room temperature can cause bacterial growth, a problem the Petlibro Polar addresses with active cooling.

Break it down

HOOK: The problem of early-morning hungry cats and the promise of automatic feeders.

+ specific: 'treated your face like a breakfast buffet at dawn'

BEST DRY FOOD PICK: Petkit YumShare Dual-Hopper 2.

+ FEATURES: Dual hopper, 1080p camera, AI food analysis, two-way audio.

+ PRICE: \$170.

GAME-CHANGER FOR WET FOOD: Petlibro Polar Smart Wet Feeder.

+ TECH: Thermoelectric cooling, sensor safety, whisker-friendly design.

+ USER IMPACT: Tester bought a second one.

BUDGET ALTERNATIVES: Granary Camera Feeder, Air Feeder, Oneisall feeder.

+ TRADE-OFF: Lower cost vs. app bugs or fewer features.

CONCLUSION: A good feeder can change your mornings and improve pet health.

Why it matters

As more households treat pets as family with busy work schedules, these smart feeders don't just offer convenience--they address real health issues like obesity and dental problems, and raise important questions about how much technology should be involved in caring for a living animal.

Test what you remember

1. Which feeder does WIRED recommend as the top choice for dry food?
 - (A) Petlibro Granary Camera Feeder
 - (B) Oneisall 2-in-1 Dual Feeder
 - (C) Petkit YumShare Dual-Hopper 2
 - (D) Petlibro Air Feeder
2. What unique feature of the Petlibro Polar Smart Wet Feeder keeps food fresh?
 - (A) A built-in water fountain
 - (B) A thermoelectric cooling system
 - (C) A vacuum-sealed lid
 - (D) A rotating tray
3. Why does the Petlibro Polar have wide, shallow stainless steel bowls?
 - (A) To fit into small kitchens
 - (B) To prevent whisker fatigue and feline acne
 - (C) To allow for larger portions
 - (D) To make cleaning easier for the owner
4. What is a downside of the Oneisall 2-in-1 Dual Feeder mentioned in the article?
 - (A) It only holds one type of food
 - (B) Its app can be buggy
 - (C) It has no camera
 - (D) It doesn't dispense wet food
5. Which budget feeder mentioned includes a rechargeable battery?
 - (A) Petlibro Granary Camera Feeder
 - (B) Petkit YumShare Dual-Hopper 2
 - (C) Petlibro Air Feeder
 - (D) Petlibro Polar Smart Wet Feeder
6. How does the Petkit YumShare Dual-Hopper 2 prevent overfeeding?
 - (A) By only dispensing at set times
 - (B) By using AI to analyze remaining food in the bowl
 - (C) By measuring the cat's weight
 - (D) By requiring manual approval from the app

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Owner Liberation (Positive): These devices let owners stay at work late or sleep in without guilt, and the portion control and fresh food options can actually improve a cat's diet. Video and AI features provide peace of mind and even fun interactions while away from home.

2. Over-Reliance and Privacy Risks (Negative/Critical): Relying too heavily on automatic feeders might cause owners to miss early signs of illness that are caught during routine manual feeding. Additionally, internet-connected cameras inside the home always carry some risk of unauthorized access or data collection by manufacturers.

3. Market Evolution (Neutral/Analytical): The pet tech industry is mirroring human smart home trends: subscription-free AI, eco-friendly materials, and integration with other devices. However, the real differentiator is whether these products actually solve specific animal welfare issues like whisker fatigue, rather than just adding flashy features.

4. Future of Pet Care (Forward-Looking): The next step might be feeders that sync with veterinary records or use image recognition to spot changes in weight, coat, or eating habits and alert owners. As AI improves, these devices could become proactive health monitors, but that raises ethical questions about giving too much caregiving responsibility to machines.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):